Obituary

In Memoriam



Bill Stegmeier and 'Pearl'.

It was with great sadness that the international pearl millet research community noted the passing away of W D 'Bill' Stegmeier on Saturday, 25 Jul 1998.

As the originator of several early-maturing, bold-seeded, dwarf pearl millet seed parents that were later widely distributed by ICRISAT to public and private sector breeding programs—especially those within India—as 842A/842B, 843A/843B, and AKM 1163/BKM 11163, Bill must be considered one of the fathers of the private sector of the pearl millet hybrid seed industry in India and of pearl millet as a grain crop in the USA (see pages 128-129 of this volume). Although he was by no means a prolific author, the extensive commercial use of products of his breeding program in India over the past decade—and his interactions with the livestock industry in the USA to evaluate and demonstrate the potential of pearl millet as a feed grain—clearly show him to have been a man of vision. Results from his research—freely shared with others long before publication—have substantially changed the way the world will look at pearl millet and other 'orphan crops' in the future.

William D 'Bill' Stegmeier, was born on 4 Oct 1931, in Green Bay, Wisconsin, USA, to William and Marie Stegmeier. He married Jean Cromer on 2 Jan 1953 in Yuma, Arizona. She passed away on 25 Jun 1996. He received his Bachelors and Masters degrees from Colorado State University, in Fort Collins, Colorado, and completed his graduate studies at South Dakota State University in Brookings, South Dakota. He worked 40 years as an agronomist, becoming an internationally recognized crop breeder for the Kansas State University Agricultural Research Center at Hays, Kansas. He started in 1958 at the K-State Agricultural Experiment Station, Garden City, moved to Hays in 1971, and retired in May 1998.

In addition to his scientific contributions in pearl millet and sunflower improvement, he was an active member of the communities in which he and his family lived—serving as a member and President of the Prairie Acres Improvement District, member and President of the Ellis County Rural Fire District, and member of the Hays City Zoning Board of Appeals. He was also a US Marine Corps veteran and served during the Korean Conflict.

Most importantly, he is remembered by his surviving children—Jill Stegmeier Herreman, William Rand Stegmeier, and Richard Stegmeier—as a true humanitarian. He instilled in them his concern about feeding the people of the world efficiently and economically. They remember fondly how, after more than one of his trips, he told his family of the great scientists he was working with, his feelings of awe for the knowledge being developed by them, and the respect and friendship he shared with them. His children indicate they grew up feeling that their father either had all the

answers or knew where to get them—although maybe not twenty years ago as rebellious youngsters when they knew that they had all the answers.

Bill was so dedicated to his research that he sowed pearl millet isolations in his own garden, miles from the experiment station, to prevent unwanted outcrossing. From his family's point of view, he 'lost' much vacation time each year to concentrate on research. Many of his Saturdays and Sundays were spent at the experiment station, making crosses, as that was when the plants were ready and pearl millet waits for no one. Bill and his wife, Jean, often kidded each other about the 'other woman' in his life, Pearl. When people who had not seen him for a period of time inquired with her about his activities, Jean would tell them that he was "still messing around with Pearl".

With Bill's passing, the global pearl millet research community has lost a quiet, productive man who will be sorely missed. The impact of Bill's pearl millet breeding program speaks for itself.

I thank Bill's colleagues and children for sharing with me their memories of this visionary, yet simple, man.

C Tom Hash
ICRISAT Pearl Millet Breeder
and
ICRISAT Technical Editor, ISMN